

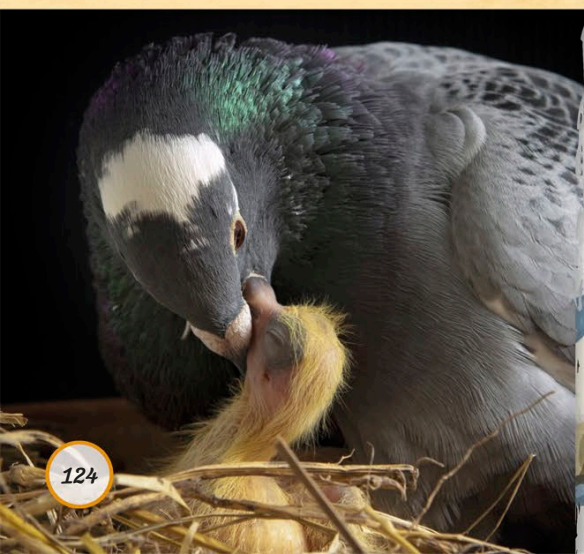
Hooded seal Female hooded seals nurse for only about four days. Their milk has the highest fat content of any mammal, so pups grow rapidly and store fat (blubber) to keep warm.



Black rhino The milk of the black rhino is one of the lowest in fat content of any mammal. Rhino calves grow slowly, nursing for as long as two years.



Pigeon The pigeon is one of the few birds that produces a milklike liquid to feed its young. The liquid is made in a muscular pouch in the bird's throat.



Courtship

In early summer, bears that are mature enough—from around five to seven years old—start to mate. Males follow the scent trail left by female footprints. They are together for only a few days.



Preparing for birth

After mating, the fertilized egg doesn't start developing in the mother's womb until fall. This ensures that her cubs will be out and about in springtime, when there's more food. To prepare for birth, she digs—and then snuggles down in—a snowy den.



The female digs a den, or snow cave, in a snowdrift. It will be only slightly larger than her body.

Winter birth

Most female polar bears give birth to twins in December and feed them with fat-rich milk. The newborns are tiny, weighing about 1 pound (500 g). They are blind and covered with short fur.

The mother polar bear lives off her fat stores for up to eight months.

